Vecna

It is said that two can keep a secret, so long as one is dead, and the dead keep secrets well, indeed - the Whispered One sees all, hears all, knows all that mortals fear to be known; only by his leave are all secrets kept, and thus all who would keep secrets must reside within the bounds of his power and grace.

Lore

History/Religion (Uncommon): Cults to a god of secret knowledge known variously as "The Whispered One" or "The Undying King" signify membership through the sigil of a clawed hand grasping a bloodshot eye, and are suspected of manipulating other sinister groups through blackmail and the lure of forbidden knowledge.
History/Religion (Esoteric): The Whispered One is spoken of throughout the multiverse, said to once have been an ancient undead king who ascended to godhood through dread ritual, leaving nothing of his original body but his hand and eye, each of which now persists as an artifact of incredible magical power.

In the days before his divinity, The Whispered One is said to have trained a great many notable dark mages, including the demon-lich Acererak, master of the Tomb of Horrors, and is claimed to be the original author of the Book of Vile Darkness and the four Tomes of the Stilled Tongue, some of the most infamous grimoires ever penned.

Defeating Vecna

Unless deprived of his divine spark, if Vecna is slain he can fashion a new body for himself, regaining his full power after 1d10 days.

Eve of Ruin. In the events of Vecna - Eve of Ruin, if Vecna is banished using the Chime of Exile, he is severed from his divine spark and reduced to merely a powerful lich on his home plane of Oerth, though is free to plot once more.

If he is reduced to 0 Hit Points without being banished, his ritual is disrupted but he returns in his full divine power after fashioning a new body for himself, using his full CR 36 avatar stat block.

Enemies

- **Kas, the Bloody Handed.** The fallen paladin Kas, once servant, seneschal and emissary of Vecna in the days when he ruled a mortal kingdom, was lured into betrayal by the corrupting influence of the evil blade Vecna forged for him.
- **Graz'zt, the Grand Indulger.** Vecna achieved his brief foray into godhood by devouring the soul of Iuz, the demigod son of Graz'zt.
- **The Circle of Eight.** The wizard conclave of Oerth known as the Circle of Eight, led by the archwizard Mordenkainen, was decimated and scattered by Vecna.



Vecna
Bastien L Deharme

Tactics

Vecna begins combat by trying to hit each foe once with his Wrest Secrets, preferring his Unhallowed Touch in between if facing divine servants, and his Serpent's Whisper if facing foes that do a great deal of damage in a single strike, or if supported by powerful allies that he can grant Opportunity Attacks with it.

If he Paralyzes a creature with his Still Ichor, he uses any remaining legendary action and both of his on-turn attacks to score automatic criticals against it with his Unhallowed Touch.

He particularly targets spellcasters in combat; whenever he sees an enemy cast a 9th level spell, he follows up by targeting them with Price of Knowledge; whenever an enemy is concentrating, he uses Dweomer Rot, and whenever a creature uses a counterspell or healing magic he retorts with Infinite Abhorrence.

With his Legendary Actions, he always follows up any use of his Drag to the Netherworld immediately with Coerced Return. Otherwise, he typically first uses Withering Glare against a martial foe to set up his Perfected Mind defence.

Eve of Ruin. In the events of Vecna - Eve of Ruin, Vecna particularly targets any creature wielding the Rod of Seven Parts or the Sword of Kas, focusing all of his efforts on killing that creature and using his Drag to the Netherworld on it as quickly as possible, then resurrecting it in his service.

He stays within the bounds of the central ritual chamber initially, but will often use his Serpent's Whisper to drive enemies through the Diamond Doors, then teleport to follow and attack them in seclusion.

Treasure

Carrying. Afterthought, Ebon Gemstones, Lich-King's Regalia, Wraithweave Cloak
Harvest. Book of Vile Darkness, Divine Spark, Eye of Vecna, Hand of Vecna, Serpent-Touched Pineal Gland
Hoard. Cult Thralls, Harvested Godflesh, Hostage Phylacteries, Untold Secrets, Warlock Binding Charms

Associated Monsters

- Allip
- Assassins
- Breathdrinker
- Death Knight
- Demiliches
- Diviners
- Liches
- Necromancers
- Nothics
- Skull Lord
- Vampires
- Vitreous Drinker
- Wheep
- Wights

A Brief Timeline of the Whispered One

- On the world of Greyhawk, an order of wizards executes a woman for necromancy and takes her child into their custody as a scribe.
- The child studies magic in secret, driven by a voice he refers to as The Serpent, until he has learned all he can, then murders the wizards and names himself Vecna.
- Vecna authors the Book of Vile Darkness, enshrining the voice's whispers in an artifact of concentrated Evil.
- Vecna uncovers the secrets of lichdom and undergoes the transformation, and is afterwards betrayed and cut down by Kas, a fallen paladin servant of his.
- After reforming his body, he departs his world to recover his lost hand and eye, and to seek a path to godhood.
- After a failed attempt at ascension, Vecna and Kas are banished into a Domain of Dread known as the Burning Peaks to war eternally.
- Vecna consumes the essence of the demigod Iuz within the city of Sigil, thereby briefly ascending to true godhood within the City of Doors.
- In short order, the Lady of Pain severs Vecna from Iuz's essence and expels him, though he afterwards retains a fragment of the divine power he once wielded and his status as a lesser god with the domain of Secrets.
- Vecna sets out once more, traveling through planes and across time to seek a return to the true godhood previously denied to him.



Vecna
Scott Murphy

Vecna, the Arch-Lich

CR 26

The withered, one-eyed figure radiates dark power beneath its regal raiment, its twisted ribs embracing a dread grimoire.

AC 18 (Lich-King's Regalia)
HP 646 (76d8 + 304)
Speed 30 ft., Fly 30 ft. (hover)

Initiative +11 (21)
Size Medium (6 ft. tall)
Type Undead

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
Str	14	+2	+2	Dex	16	+3	+11	Con	18	+4	+12
Int	22	+6	+14	Wis	24	+7	+15	Cha	16	+3	+11

Skills Arcana +22, History +14, Insight +15, Perception +15
Immunities Necrotic, Poison; Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Poisoned, Turned
Senses Truesight 120 ft., Passive Perception 25
Languages All
Drives Apotheosis, Curiosity, Domination, Ego, Vengeance
XP 90,000
Proficiency Bonus +8

Traits

Vilespeech Casting. Whenever Vecna casts a spell, each other creature in a 15-foot Emanation that can hear him takes 10 (3d6) Psychic damage.

Perfected Mind. If Vecna fails a saving throw while Concentrating, he can stop Concentrating to succeed instead.

At the end of each of his turns, Vecna can end one Condition affecting him or destroy a barrier containing him.

Actions

Multiattack. Vecna makes two attacks with his Unhallowed Touch or Serpent's Whisper, one of which he can replace with a use of his Wrest Secrets.

Unhallowed Touch (Level 4 Spell). *Melee Spell Attack:* +14, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 42 (4d10 + 20) Necrotic damage.

If the target is wielding a holy symbol, it can choose to either take an additional 22 (4d10) Necrotic damage or have the holy symbol crumble to dust.

Serpent's Whisper (Level 5 Spell). *Ranged Spell Attack:* +14, range 30 ft. *Hit:* 35 (10d6) Psychic damage and Vecna can force the target to move up to 15 feet or make a weapon attack under his control.

Wrest Secrets (Level 7 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet must make a **Intelligence Saving Throw:** DC 22. **Failure:** 42 (12d6) Psychic damage plus one of the following effects:

- Vecna can end one spell effect affecting the target.
- Vecna learns the target's two weakest saving throws.
- Vecna gains Advantage on the next saving throw he makes in the next minute against an ability the target controls.
- The target has Disadvantage on attacks it makes against Vecna until the end of its next turn.

A creature keeping any significant secret from its closest allies has Disadvantage on this saving throw.

Price of Knowledge (Level 8 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet can choose to unprepare up to three of its prepared spells, then takes 4 (1d8) Psychic damage per spell it has prepared.

Ashen Silence (Level 9 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet begins Suffocating. At the end of each of its turns, the target takes 27 (5d10) Fire plus 27 (5d10) Necrotic damage, then makes a **Constitution Saving Throw:** DC 22. **Success:** The effect ends.

A creature that would be killed while under the effect of this spell is instead Petrified with 0 Hit Points, and disintegrates if it takes any damage from another source.

Bonus Actions

Dweomer-Rot (Level 6 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet that is either Concentrating on a spell or that is the target of a spell being Concentrated on takes 11 (2d10) Necrotic damage per level of the spell.

Drag to the Netherworld. One corpse or creature with 0 Hit Points within 60 feet must make a **Charisma Saving Throw:** DC 22. **Failure:** The creature dies and its body disappears to a hidden demiplane.

Reactions

Still Ichor (Level 5 Spell). **Trigger:** A creature hits Vecna with a melee attack. **Response:** The creature must make a **Wisdom Saving Throw:** DC 22. **Failure:** The creature is Frightened and Paralyzed until the start of its next turn.

Infinite Abhorrence (Level 9 Spell). **Trigger:** A creature Vecna can see within 60 feet casts a spell of Level 1 or above. **Response:** The creature loses the ability to cast that spell until cured with a Wish spell or similar magic.

Legendary Actions

Vecna can take two legendary actions, choosing from the options below.

Vile Stride. Vecna teleports to an unoccupied space within 30 feet and can use his Serpent's Whisper.

Withering Glare (Concentration). Vecna fixes his eye upon a creature he can see within 120 feet, giving it Disadvantage on all d20 Tests that use Strength or Dexterity.

At the start of each of its turns, the creature takes 18 (4d8) Necrotic damage and ages 10% of its natural lifespan until cured by Greater Restoration.

Coerced Return (Costs 2 Actions). Vecna raises the last creature affected by his Drag to the Netherworld to undeath in his service, conjuring it to an unoccupied space within 60 feet.

The creature's type becomes Undead and it gains Vulnerability to Radiant damage, otherwise retaining its own statistics.

Vecna, the Whispered One

CR 36

The withered, one-eyed figure writhes with silent shades, an aura of unvoiced shrieks heralding a dark divinity's presence.

AC 22 (Lich-King's Regalia)
HP 1125 (90d8 + 720)
Speed 30 ft., Fly 30 ft. (hover)

Initiative +12 (22)
Size Medium (6 ft. tall)
Type Undead (Avatar)

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
Str	21	+5	+5	Dex	16	+3	+12	Con	26	+8	+17
Int	25	+7	+16	Wis	24	+7	+16	Cha	25	+7	+16

Skills Arcana +25, History +16, Insight +16, Perception +16
Immunities Necrotic, Poison; Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Poisoned, Turned
Senses Truesight 120 ft., Passive Perception 26
Languages All
Drives Apotheosis, Curiosity, Domination, Ego, Vengeance
XP 275,000
Proficiency Bonus +9

Traits

Vilespeech Casting. Whenever Vecna casts a spell, each other creature in a 15-foot Emanation that can hear him takes 10 (3d6) Psychic damage.

Perfected Mind. If Vecna fails a saving throw while Concentrating, he can stop Concentrating to succeed instead.

At the end of each of his turns, Vecna can end one Condition affecting him or destroy a barrier containing him.

Actions

Multiattack. Vecna makes two attacks with his Unhallowed Touch, one of which he can replace with a use of his Serpent's Whisper, Wrest Secrets, Price of Knowledge, or Ashen Silence.

Unhallowed Touch (Level 9 Spell). *Melee Spell Attack:* +16, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 67 (4d10 + 45) Necrotic damage.

If the target is wielding a holy symbol, it can choose to either take an additional 22 (4d10) Necrotic damage or have the holy symbol crumble to dust.

Serpent's Whisper (Level 9 Spell). *Ranged Spell Attack:* +16, range 30 ft. *Hit:* 63 (18d6) Psychic damage and Vecna can force the target to move up to 15 feet or make a weapon attack under his control.

Wrest Secrets (Level 9 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet must make a **Intelligence Saving Throw:** DC 24. **Failure:** 42 (12d6) Psychic damage plus three of the following effects:

- Vecna can end one spell effect affecting the target.
- Vecna learns the target's two weakest saving throws.
- Vecna gains Advantage on the next saving throw he makes in the next minute against an ability the target controls.
- The target has Disadvantage on attacks it makes against Vecna until the end of its next turn.

A creature keeping any significant secret from its closest allies has Disadvantage on this saving throw.

Price of Knowledge (Level 8 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet can choose to unprepare up to three of its prepared spells, then takes 4 (1d8) Psychic damage per spell it has prepared.

Ashen Silence (Level 9 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet begins Suffocating. At the end of each of its turns, the target takes 27 (5d10) Fire plus 27 (5d10) Necrotic damage, then makes a **Constitution Saving Throw:** DC 24. **Success:** The effect ends.

A creature that would be killed while under the effect of this spell is instead Petrified with 0 Hit Points, and disintegrates if it takes any damage from another source.

Bonus Actions

Dweomer-Rot (Level 6 Spell). One creature Vecna can see within 60 feet that is either Concentrating on a spell or that is the target of a spell being Concentrated on takes 11 (2d10) Necrotic damage per level of the spell.

Drag to the Netherworld. One corpse or creature with 0 Hit Points within 60 feet must make a **Charisma Saving Throw:** DC 24. **Failure:** The creature dies and its body disappears to a hidden demiplane.

Reactions

Still Ichor (Level 5 Spell). **Trigger:** A creature hits Vecna with a melee attack. **Response:** The creature must make a **Wisdom Saving Throw:** DC 24. **Failure:** The creature is Frightened and Paralyzed until the start of its next turn.

Infinite Abhorrence (Level 9 Spell). **Trigger:** A creature Vecna can see within 60 feet casts a spell of Level 1 or above. **Response:** The creature loses the ability to cast that spell until cured with a Wish spell or similar magic.

Legendary Actions

Vecna can take three legendary actions, choosing from the options below.

Vile Stride. Vecna teleports to an unoccupied space within 30 feet and can use his Serpent's Whisper.

Withering Glare (Concentration). Vecna fixes his eye upon a creature he can see within 120 feet, giving it Disadvantage on all d20 Tests that use Strength or Dexterity.

At the start of each of its turns, the creature takes 36 (8d8) Necrotic damage and ages 20% of its natural lifespan until cured by Greater Restoration.

Coerced Return (Costs 2 Actions). Vecna raises the last creature affected by his Drag to the Netherworld to undeath in his service, conjuring it to an unoccupied space within 60 feet.

The creature's type becomes Undead and it gains Vulnerability to Radiant damage, otherwise retaining its own statistics.

Unhallowed Touch

Level 4 Necromancy (Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action
Range: Touch
Components: V, S, M (stone from a shattered altar)
Duration: Instantaneous

You reach forth in opposition to the divine, wreathed in negative energies. Make a melee spell attack.

On a hit, the target takes 4d10 + 20 Necrotic damage.

A target hit by this attack that is wielding a holy symbol can choose to have the holy symbol crumble to dust. If it does not, it takes an additional 4d10 Necrotic damage.

Using a Higher Level Spell Slot. The bonus to the initial Necrotic damage increases by 5 for each spell level above 4.

Serpent's Whisper

Level 5 Illusion (Bard, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action
Range: 60 feet
Components: V
Duration: Instantaneous

You call forth whispers of ancient evil to drive a creature briefly to madness. Make a ranged spell attack against a creature in range.

On a hit, the target takes 10d6 Psychic damage and you can compel the target to move up to 15 feet in a direction of your choice or make a weapon attack against a target of your choice.

Using a Higher Level Spell Slot. The Psychic damage increases by 2d6 for each spell slot level above 5.

Still Ichor

Level 5 Enchantment (Bard, Cleric, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard)

Casting Time: Reaction, which you take when a creature hits with a melee attack
Range: Touch
Components: V, S
Duration: 1 round

You wreath yourself in raw magical menace, forcing the attacker to succeed on a Wisdom Saving Throw or be Frightened and Paralyzed until the start of its next turn.

Dweomer-Rot

Level 6 Necromancy (Cleric, Druid, Sorcerer, Wizard, Warlock)

Casting Time: Bonus Action
Range: 60 feet
Components: V, S
Duration: Instantaneous

You flood the threads of magic maintaining a spell with negative energy.

One creature you can see within range that is either Concentrating on a spell or that is the target of a spell that is being Concentrated on takes 2d10 Necrotic damage per level of the spell.

Wrest Secrets

Level 7 Divination (Bard, Cleric, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action
Range: 60 feet
Components: V, S, M (a liar's tongue)
Duration: Instantaneous

You force one creature you can see within range to make an Intelligence Saving Throw. On a failure, the target takes 12d6 Psychic damage and suffers one of the following effects:

- You can end one spell effect affecting the target.
- You learn the target's two weakest saving throws.
- You gain Advantage on the next saving throw you make in the next minute against an ability the target controls.
- The target has Disadvantage on attacks it makes against you until the end of its next turn. A creature keeping any significant secret from its closest allies has Disadvantage on this saving throw.

Using a Higher Level Spell Slot. You can choose one additional effect for each spell slot level above 7.

Price of Knowledge

Level 8 Enchantment (Cleric, Warlock)

Casting Time: Action
Range: 60 feet
Components: V, S
Duration: Instantaneous

You twist a creature's hoarded magical secrets against them.

One creature you can see within range can choose to unprepare up to three of its prepared spells, then takes 1d8 Psychic damage per spell it has prepared.

If the target is a spellcaster that does not prepare spells, it instead takes 2d8 Psychic damage per level of the highest level spell it can cast.

Ashen Silence

Level 9 Evocation (Druid, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action
Range: 60 feet
Components: V, S, M (a smoldering coal)
Duration: Instantaneous

One creature you can see within 60 feet begins Suffocating. At the end of each of its turns, the target takes 5d10 Fire damage plus 5d10 Necrotic damage, then makes a Constitution Saving Throw. On a success, the effect ends for the target.

A creature that would be killed while under the effect of this spell is instead Petrified with 0 Hit Points and automatically stabilizes.

If the target takes any damage from another source while Petrified in this way, it disintegrates into a puff of ash.

Infinite Abhorrence

Level 9 Enchantment (Bard, Cleric, Druid, Warlock)

Casting Time: Reaction, which you take when a creature you can see within range casts a spell of Level 1 or above.
Range: 60 feet
Components: V, S
Duration: Instantaneous

The target creature loses the ability to cast the triggering spell until cured with a Wish spell or similar magic.



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Art Credits

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- Vecna by Scott Murphy
- Vecna by Kieran Yanner

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Goblin by Rae Elderidge

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